The size of the exodus or ‘Republikflucht’ from Berlin – which had already taken 3 million Germans out of the East since 1949 – rose to an alarming figure of 1,000 persons a day during July and August 1958. This endless paralysis was caused by political crackdowns and the unbeatably higher standard of living in the Western world and the opportunities for more liberal ways of life. During the first half of the year, figures revealed no fewer than 621 doctors and dentists, 1,392 schoolteachers, 85 scientific assistants and 200 professors, lecturers and other academicians had fled West, leaving faculties in the world-famous universities of Halle, Leipzig, Dresden and Jena, denuded of their best men.

As the staggering exodus continued, Ulbricht tooted his own horn. On 12 July 1958, he took to the floor of the Fifth SED Congress to boast that East German living standards would quickly surpass those of the FRG. Moreover, Moscow, he said, had agreed to triple deliveries of iron, steel, copper and other raw materials.3

From here on, Ulbricht’s great Socialist revolution would see the GDR make the transition from five to seven-year planning. In agriculture – despite the shortages of 1953 – forced collectivisation was ramped up; while private companies were more firmly integrated into the planned economy. Standing witness to the Fifth SED Congress, Khrushchev flew into East Berlin to add his endorsement.

‘We want to live in peace and to attack no one,’ he told a rally of 200,000 people. At a reception, a rare flash of unity between Ulbricht and Khrushchev was caught on film, it was a brief and friendly moment but probably uncomfortable for both. The two had known each other in Stalingrad in 1943, where Khrushchev witnessed Ulbricht using a megaphone to appeal to German troops to lay down their arms. ‘He would crawl around at night for a long time, and when he came in, we would have dinner with him, and would report how many Germans had surrendered.’

On the same platform at the Fifth Congress, Honecker’s position was also strengthened. After his status as a full member of the Politburo and secretary of the National Defence Council was affirmed, he spoke about the military in stark terms, saying training, morale and leadership all needed to be addressed.4 He pushed for greater SED involvement in the national army